Yuan China & The Ming Dynasty

By Mustafa Asif and Salah Hassan

Table of contents

01 Comparison of Dynasties
Notable Characteristics, Economy, Politics, Religion

02 Important Figures
Kublai Khan, Zheng He, Zhu Yuanzhang

01

Comparison of Dynasties

Notable Characteristics, Economy, Politics, Religion

Notable Characteristics

Yuan China

- The first foreign dynasty in Chinese history, established by Kublai Khan.
- Defined by a four-class social hierarchy.
- Known for trade along the Silk Road and the Pax Mongolica, a period of peace and stability.
- Developed paper money and porcelain.

Ming Dynasty

- Characterized by a population boom, which was caused by a food surplus.
- Known for advancements in literature.
- Restored the Great Wall, and built the Forbidden City.
- Conducted large naval expeditions through Zheng He and his fleet.

Economy

Yuan

The Yuan economy was a mixed system, combining internal agriculture and external trade. Key aspects of their economy were widespread use of paper money and the Silk Road, as well as maritime trade. Inflation led to the collapse of the Yuan economy.

Ming

The Ming Dynasty had the world's largest economy at the time. This economy was characterized by agriculture surpluses, population growth, technological innovations, and commercialization The economy transitioned from money-based to mostly silver.

Politics

Yuan Dynasty

There were four castes:

1. Mongols
2. Semu-ren (Central Asians)
3. Han Chinese
4. Southerners

The capital was moved from Shangdu to modern-day Beijing, which remains the capital of China to this day. After their fall, the Ming Dynasty took control of China.

Ming Dynasty

Emperor Hongwu founded the Ming Dynasty. Hongwu had a paranoid rule, in which he concentrated power and established a secret police to spy on political opponents and protect him. Recruitment for government positions in the Ming Dynasty differed from previous dynasties; people had to take a civil service exam to even be considered. Later in the dynasty, the emperor was captured, and following rulers were weak and corrupt, leading to the rise of the Qing Dynasty.

Religion

Yuan	Although the state religion of the Yuan was Buddhism, religious beliefs under the Yuan Dynasty were diverse, and this was a result of the religious tolerance of the government. Some examples of religions during this time period included Buddhism, Confucianism, Taoism, Islam, and Christianity.	Ming	Religion under the Ming was less diverse. The government adopted Confucianism as the official religion, but many also practiced Taoism, Buddhism, and other folk religions. Islam was also tolerated, and many in government positions practiced it. Toward the end of the empire Christian missionaries started coming into China, but not many accepted it, considering it to be a “western religion”.

02

Important Figures

Kublai Khan, Zheng He, Zhu Yuanzhang

Kublai Khan

Kublai Khan, the grandson of Genghis Khan, played a fundamental role in shaping Chinese history by becoming the founder of the Yuan Dynasty. Unlike earlier Mongol leaders who focused on conquest, Kublai worked to fully unite China under one government. After defeating the Song Dynasty, he became the first foreign ruler to control all of China.

Kublai Khan (continued)

Kubali established his capital in what is now Beijing and adopted many Chinese traditions of goerning, while still maintaining Mongol influence. Under his rule, trade expanded significantly especially along to Silk Road, connecting China more closely with Europe and the Middle East. Travelers such as Marco Polo even visted his court, helping spread knowledge of China to the world. However, his rule also created divisions between Mongols and Chinese citizens, which caused some tension within society.

Zheng He

Zheng He was a famous Musloim admiral during the Ming Dynasty who led some of the largest naval expeditions in history. Serving under the Yongle Emperor, Zheng He commanded enormous fleet knows as “treasure ships,” which sailed across the Indian Ocean and reached as far as East Africa.

Zheng He (continued)

Rather than conquering land, Zheng He's voyage focused on diplomacy and trade. He established relationships with foreign rulers, showcased China's wealth and power, and expanded China's influence across many regions. His expeditions brought back valuable goods, rare animals, and new ideas. These journeys greatly strengthened China's economy and helped build a vast international trade network, making China a dominant global presence during that time.

Zhu Yuanzhang

Zhu Yuanzhang, later known as the Hongwu Emperor, rose from extreme poverty to become one of China's most important rulers. He founded the Ming Dynasty after leading a successful rebellion against the Mongol-led Yuan Dynasty. His rise to power marked the return of native Chinese rule after years of foreign control.

Zhu Yuanzhang (continued)

As emperor, Zhu focused heavily on rebuilding and statustabilizing China. HeHe supported farmers by reducing taxes and encouraging agriculture, which helped to revive the economy. He also promoted traditional Chinese values, especially Confucian ideas, and created a strong centralized government to maintain order. Although he strict and sometimes harsh ruler, his leadership brought stability and laid the foundation for one of China's most prosperous dynasties